"Certainly," he said, and handed me the pencil.

I placed a dark X against Roosevelt's name (which suited Silverman, whose voting intentions were identical with mine). I was very pleased with that, and infinitely more pleased when Roosevelt won the election.

And then, on October 16, 1940, the United States initiated the machinery for its first peacetime draft. Registration was confined to those who were over twenty-one, however, and, temporarily, I was not affected. On October 28, Italy invaded Greece.

Making My Literary Mark

There were touches of brightness in that generally gloomy literary autumn.

In the September 1940 Super Science Stories, my story "Robbie" appeared. 1 Fred Pohl had once again displayed his penchant for changing titles. He called it "Strange Playfellow." I had accepted "The Callistan Menace," but this one I rejected. My title "Robbie" made the robot-nursemaid the center of the story, whereas "Strange Playfellow" made him merely an oddity. When the time came that the story was introduced into one of my collections and was anthologized several times, I insisted on the use of "Robbie" as the title. Except for that one first appearance in the magazine, it has never been called anything else.

Better yet was the appearance of the December 1940 Astonishing, which reached the stands on October 24. It contained "Half-Breeds on Venus" 2 as the lead novelette, that is, as the first story in the magazine —the position of pride. It was my tenth published story and the first time I had taken the lead.

What's more, I had the cover. I don't mean that I had my name on the cover—that much had happened twice before. I had both the title of the story and my full name on the cover; and what's more, the cover illustration depicted a scene from the story. That was the first time that, in that sense, I had made the cover.

It was a very satisfactory forward step.

I took others. After reading "Robbie" in cold print in the magazine, I decided I liked it more than any other story I had written yet. It also occurred to me that robot stories would not involve me in any superiority/inferiority hassle with Campbell. Why not, then, write another?